

Refuse and reject

Learner workbook

Decline an action or turn down an offer.

Understand the distinction

Refuse can take to + verb: I refused to sign. It can also take an offer or request: refuse an invitation. Reject commonly takes a noun naming something not accepted: reject a proposal, reject an application.

Do not use reject to do for declining an action. Either verb can sound strong depending on context. Decline is often a courteous choice for an invitation. State a reason or an alternative when it helps the conversation, without inventing one.

Compare the patterns

ACTION

She refused to sign the form.

Refuse takes a to-infinitive.

PROPOSAL

They rejected the proposal.

Reject takes the proposal as its object.

INVITATION

Thank you, but I must decline.

A courteous way to turn down an invitation.

Read each example. Explain what the highlighted choice means in context. Then cover the example and say a similar sentence.

Check your understanding

Write before looking at the answers. The guide gives a model answer and explains the choice. Other wording can be correct.

1. Complete: He refused ___ answer.

2. Correct this: They rejected to meet us.

3. Can refuse take a noun?

Use it in your own life

Decline an invitation politely without adding a false reason.

Self-check

Does your sentence express your intended meaning? Does its form follow the relevant pattern? Can a reader understand the context?

Try again

After checking the explanation, revise your sentence. Say it aloud or use it in a short conversation.

Answers and explanation

1. to

Use refuse to do something.

2. They refused to meet us.

Reject does not take this to-infinitive pattern.

3. Yes: refuse an invitation or refuse help.

Its patterns are broader than refuse to do.

One possible response

Thank you for inviting me, but I cannot join you this time.

This is a model, not the only acceptable answer. Assess meaning, grammar, and context together.

Continue learning

Web lesson and related topics: englishladder.com/grammar-concepts/concept-41.html